Brahmins at twenty-one (21.4 per cent) and Thakurs at eighteen (18.3 per cent). The ascendance of OBCs at this micro-level of the BJP's organisational structures forms a striking contrast with a much lower number of Brahmins and Thakurs as well as the continuing marginality of Dalits at this level. This suggests (Figure 3.6) that the caste shift within the BJP is an ongoing project. Overall, upper castes taken together do dominate among district presidents and SCs remain very few (six, 6.1 per cent). The change started with the OBCs at the ground level and is very much a work in progress—especially with SCs, who are the target group for the BJP's next phase of consolidation.

The point, as one politician explained, is that, on caste, voters do not necessarily see these representation numbers in isolation but with a broader sense of where a party is going. Politics is about balancing vying factions. At the local level, if someone from a particular caste gets a ticket, then someone else gets made district president and yet another person may get a Vidhan Sabha ticket. In 2014, for example, when he was on the campaign trail in Pilibhit, the journalist Brijesh Shukla remembers being told emphatically by local politicians that the BJP would win that seat. When he asked why, they pointed out that the SP had just removed its district president, who happened to be a Maurya OBC. He was replaced by a Yadav. The BJP promptly appointed the out-of-favour Maurya district president as its own district president in Pilibhit. 'People take these things very seriously and they matter a lot,' he recalled. These micro-adjustments at the ground level are what moved OBC voters towards the BJP. 'In reality, castes want a share. Now fake hissedaari [sharing] will not work. It won't happen with Modi's tweet, or with Rahul Gandhi's tweet. It will happen with real power-sharing.'[49]

Figure 3.6: Caste Composition of the BJP's District Presidents in UP, 2020